Enlightenment itself seem secular and non-Christian because after all, why would a Christian movement preach toleration for other faith systems when proselytisation remains one of the cornerstones of that faith? But did toleration truly have a non-religious origin? Also, did toleration mean the ability to practise one's conscience without being judged or without having to apprehend proselytisation? These are the questions that De Roover addresses with scintillating clarity.

To start with, De Roover examines the views of one of the central figures of the Enlightenment, the English philosopher John Locke, who contributed significantly to the development of liberalism with his views on religious toleration, equality and the concept of rights. De Roover compares and contrasts two schools of thought—the first which interprets Locke's views as liberal and hence secular, and the second which sees the Protestant framework clearly at play behind Locke's positions,[28] divorced from which theological framework and its premises, several of his claims would be 'simply unintelligible'. De Roover explains the relevance of this examination especially for non-Christian societies because a liberal model of toleration that draws significantly from the Protestant framework is bound to interfere with the course of such societies, unless they share the same underlying ontological and theological premises, which cannot be said of most indigenous societies. If anything, as discussed in the previous chapters, the Christian understanding of the relationship between 'God', human beings and nature is as divergent as it can get from those cultures that venerate nature and see themselves as part of nature and not outside of it. This effectively undermines any semblance of a common ground between the worldview of indigenous societies and that of Christian Europe.

Does this mean that it is not possible to base liberalism on purely secular values? To answer this, Jeremy Waldron, professor of law and philosophy, says that while it may be possible to build the edifice of liberalism and equality on non-Christian foundations, as a matter of 'ethical history' it must be acknowledged that the 'modern' thought around equality has been shaped by religion, specifically Christianity.[29] He suspects that the contemporary notion of equality among human beings might fall apart without the underlying Christian premise. In other words, contemporary equality and liberalism are, in fact, secularised versions of Christian equality and Christian liberalism. Given the global presence of European